

The Problem of Theological Method: I

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THE PROBLEM OF THEOLOGICAL METHOD

[These two articles on theological method were presented as papers by Edwin A. Burt and Paul Tillich at the spring meeting of the American Theological Society in New York.]

I

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I. THE APPROACH

TWO main approaches to the problem of an adequate method in theology would seem to be pertinent and necessary. The historical approach throws light on any problem; a methodological problem, in particular, becomes clarified when one surveys the reasons for the methods employed in the past and considers their virtues and defects. And since theology is an interpretation of religion, the religious approach is in its case essential; no method in theology can be appropriate which is not an expression of the clearest and most dependable insights of religion.

a) *Historical: 1. Methods of the past.*—The theological methods which have seemed persuasive and have been widely influential in past epochs of Western history are in each case the result of applying to the field of religion the methods that appeared successful and promising in secular thought at the time. In its detail, of course, each important method

took account of the differences between religion and other subject matter, but in its general structure it was directly patterned after the method which had justified itself in the philosophy and science of the period and was being carried in those fields to new conquests.

In the Occident, to date, there have been three major methods besides the irrationalism which in a negative sense constitutes a fourth.

The first may be called the *authoritarian-deductive* method. It arose from the application to theological problems of the basic methodological principles of Platonic philosophy, with the latter's confidence in mathematics and dialectic; the one basic feature which is not Platonic is its appeal to authority rather than to reason to supply its axiomatic principles. This method prevailed as long as Platonism provided the perspective in terms of which serious thinking in all subjects developed. The earliest thinker to employ this method systematically in dealing with the theoretical problems of Christian thought was Origen. Taking the accumulated tradition as an authoritative source, he apprehends by noetic insight the fundamental general truths, such as that God

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in his essential nature is spirit, and proceeds by deductive inference to the various detailed truths that they imply. These detailed truths are then confirmed by appeal to scriptural texts. This procedure is evident everywhere. Even his conclusions regarding specific questions of method—such as: On what matters can we be certain, and where must we be content with a problematic result? Where shall we use literal and where allegorical interpretations of the text?—are reached by employing this general method.

The second may be called the *empirico-metaphysical* method. It arose from the application to theology of Aristotelian methodological principles with their emphasis on perceptual induction, and it prevailed during the period when Aristotelianism was in the ascendancy. The outstanding historical representative is Thomas Aquinas. His method is empirical in that, instead of starting with some assumed authority or with intuitive insight, he starts with the facts of sense experience. It is metaphysical in that he also assumes from the start certain canons for the causal explanation of these facts; and those canons are such that, when systematically applied, they lead to an ultimate metaphysical ground of all objects and changes in the world. The affirmations about this ground, justified by this procedure, then serve as final principles from which detailed doctrines can be deduced. That this is his basic method is shown in the same way as with Origen; it is employed to justify the answers given to more specific questions of method, such as: Where shall the line be drawn between the matters which can be dealt with by natural reason and those which can be solved only by the aid of faith in revelation?

The third may be called the *experiential* method. It arose from the theological application of the principles of modern empirical science in its commitment to the way of hypothesis-deduction-verification. The historical pioneer in this type of theological method was Schleiermacher. By a preliminary analysis of the religious experience of men (religious "consciousness" is his preferred term) he derives proposed definitions of the fundamental religious concepts and tentative hypotheses for explaining the facts of religion in terms of those concepts. These hypotheses are then tested by further appeal to relevant religious experiences and are either accepted as verified doctrines or rejected as inconsistent with the data. Even the verified doctrines are provisional rather than final; they are subject to correction when the facts of experience change or when the hypotheses are applied to a different religious group.

In addition to these three, there have been many minor methodologies; some would have become major ones had it not been for historical accident. For example, the mathematical rationalism worked out by Spinoza—one of the most profound theological systems ever written—never gained effectiveness because the historical circumstances which gave its method plausibility passed away long before people were able on any wide scale to accept its ruthless realism and its honest rigor. There have been many attempts to combine two or more of these methods.

In each of these three methodological epochs, especially at times of social crisis, thinkers have appeared who rejected the very possibility of any method of gaining religious knowledge by rational investigation. These are the irrationalists in theology. They see that any such method assumes, on the one hand, the essential

competence of human reason and, on the other, the immanence of God in the world, which is accessible to that reason. The former assumption they reject unqualifiedly; the latter they reject so far as concerns what is basic in the nature and activity of God. From their viewpoint, man can only wait in more or less helpless receptivity for God's saving grace to break in upon him from the transcendent realm; only then can his reason, purged of sin and pride, acquire what power it may to expound helpfully to others the redeeming Word. But mere exposition of conclusions accepted without the use of reason is not a theological method comparable to the methods here described. Hence, irrationalism is a form of methodology in the negative sense in which skepticism is a form of epistemology; it simply claims to show that no positive method is possible and why.

Since we cannot return to this theme later, it is well to become clear about the nature of irrationalism and the role it actually plays in theology. I mean by a theological method a procedure, which man can work out and critically appraise, for the attainment of systematic understanding in religion. The rationalist in theology is convinced that such a procedure is possible because he believes that whoever is sincerely seeking truth is seeking God—not that the two are identical but that they are inseparable. Hence he is sure that an appropriate method must employ those means of inquiry and communication that are shared by all sincere seekers after truth, however they may differ in their present beliefs. To adopt those means is to commit one's self to the exercise of reason, for reason is the human faculty which has this essential property. Irrationalism holds that no such procedure is available, save in the minor form of inferring

detailed doctrines from premises which are adopted without the exercise of reason. It holds this because the irrationalist believes that men can seek truth as sincerely as they know how without seeking God; man's mind is naturally so corrupt that what it takes to be truth may be very different from the real essence of God. Hence its criterion is a nonrational one. In terms of its assumptions, any rational criterion—by which the insights claimed can be domesticated within men's shared experience and coherently related to everything else that they know and prize—is impossible. A gulf sunders the redeemed from the unredeemed; the sincere doubter is given no way by which he can communicate on common terms with the irrationalist theologian so that the two might test together the validity of the latter's assertions.

Seeing nothing that I can have greater confidence in than reason, I am unpersuaded by this doctrine. Hence the only valuable role that I can find irrationalism filling is a negative one; it serves as a searching critic of whatever interpretations rationalistic theologies have offered. Wherever they have made unwarranted pretensions, it discloses them; it reminds us that, especially in the field of religion, what we have not yet comprehended is far greater than we have blithely supposed; it forces us to become humbly aware of our limitations in the presence of transcendent reality. When previous attempts at rational theology have failed, the only way of constructive advance is to try again—to try harder and more persistently with the clearest possible awareness of the specific points at which failure is most evident. Whatever paradoxes have appeared must be removed by a better analysis. So far as the good that religion can contribute to the ordering of human experience still

lies beyond the comprehension of reason, the task of the responsible theologian is not just to wait for it to break in upon him and then expound it in its transcendent otherness but to find dependable ways of bringing it within the range of man's common articulate experience so that we can use the most comprehensive wisdom available in seeing how to think and what to do because of its presence. Of course, at any given time there is much more in God than we are able to comprehend. But we can draw no positive results for human guidance from ignorance; only so far as God is cognized in some definite concepts can we do anything in thought or action because of contact with his reality, not so far as he is a principle lying beyond our comprehension. To engage in the responsible task of rendering our confrontation by the divine intelligible in terms that can be shared with all serious inquirers is to participate in the activity of reason in theology. Whatever results are reached will be expressed in the form of definitions of basic religious concepts and of a systematic set of doctrines claiming to express religious understanding, and whatever procedure is followed in reaching them will constitute a theological method.

In an age of crisis this activity of reason, though especially difficult, is more desperately needed than at other times. The need today is more urgent than ever before, and reason can no longer afford to accept any limit to the social universality which is its intrinsic property. It is a matter of life or death now that men become able to live in one world; a good religion and a good theology will be an aid in this transformation, not an obstacle to it. Men must be world citizens—politically, economically, educationally, religiously. And religious world citi-

zenship is the foundation of peaceful unity in other spheres; when it is absent, sectarianism cannot help but permeate in its ominous divisiveness all other phases of human culture. It is the distinctive task of theology today to clarify the stable conditions of religious world citizenship; and irrationalism, which in practice always buttresses some sectarian tradition, cannot even begin to perform this task.

2. *A method now emerging.*—Now it seems to me clear that the methods of secular thought whose application to religion has yielded the theological methods here examined have reached the end of their day and are in process of being superseded by a new, more adequate, and more inclusive procedure. By saying that they have reached the end of their day I mean that their claim to provide a universal method is no longer plausible; the limited area within which they can do their job successfully has now been marked out, and the distinctive problems of other areas can be seen with sufficient definiteness so that some features of the new method needed to deal with them are emerging into clarity. The method of Platonic rationalism is now seen to be validly applicable to the field of mathematics; and, when it is restricted to that field instead of applied to the entire universe, its foundation principles become proposed postulates instead of absolute definitions or axioms. Aristotelianism is seen to be a hybrid method—its rationalistic side valid when given a mathematical interpretation and its empirical side valid when subsumed under the sounder methodology of modern factual science. The experiential method has shown itself to be valid when restricted to the description and correlation of facts, by the inductive canons which successful empirical science has

developed. In the light of this consideration it has become increasingly evident that the experiential method is inapplicable to problems involving the critical comparison of values or the interrelations between facts and values. What values are actually adopted at any given time and place and what happens when they guide action are, of course, matters of fact to be empirically studied; but what values *should* be preferred when alternatives are confronted is not a matter of fact and cannot be solved by any process of inductive generalization. Another method is needed to deal with such problems as these.

Since religious experience includes choices between alternative values and an adjustment to the interrelations between value and fact, religion constitutes an area in which none of these methods is adequate. And the extent and nature of the inadequacy has become fairly clear from the many systematic attempts to apply the experiential method to religion. When employed in the explanation of facts, the method is successful because in that field inductive hypotheses can be formulated accurately enough and because the experiences which would verify a hypothesis can be described in advance with sufficient objectivity so that, when the verification is carried out, one can decide impartially whether the predicted experience has come to pass and the hypothesis is confirmed or whether it has failed and the hypothesis is proved erroneous. These virtues apparently cannot be realized in religion. An issue between two competing religious doctrines is an issue of values as well as of fact; the opposing champions may accept all the relevant facts while being committed to diverse sets of ultimate values. No appeal to perceptual material can decide such an issue, be-

cause the same facts are differently valued. Whatever values are assumed in a proposed hypothesis will be found also in the facts presented as a verification of that hypothesis; thus each antagonist, if he has not been too naïve in formulating his theory, finds it verified. Under these circumstances the process of verification has no differentiating power; it cannot confirm one thinker's doctrine and reject another's but can only add apparently new strength to the basic appraisals already adopted.

An illustration of this situation will clarify the contention just made. How could the fundamental issue between Catholicism and Protestantism be decided by appeal to experienced facts? The champions of either view accept all the facts that could be adduced by the champions of the other and are familiar with them. And, should scriptural proof texts be brought into the account, each side can pounce upon its own favored texts; each has its carefully developed technique for debunking the texts on which the other pins its faith. The issue is not an issue of fact; it is, rather: How should the mutually accepted facts be interpreted so that the highest religious values can be realized in their presence? And here the radical divergence comes to light—a divergence irreducible to factual considerations. From the Catholic viewpoint the highest values are those which are realized through the dependence of the individual on the authority of the ecclesiastical community—for it, *extra ecclesiam nulla salus*. From the Protestant viewpoint they are those which are realized through the responsible freedom of the individual to find saving truth through his own conscience and faith; for it, the whole priestly apparatus is an obstruction, not a door, between man and God. Analyze the reasoning of the Cath-

olic theologian; the value-commitment which emerges in his conclusions was already present, however disguised, in his premises. Had it not been, those premises would never have allowed him to pass without a violent leap to his conclusions. Analyze the Protestant's reasoning; the value-commitment appearing in his conclusions was likewise present in his premises, and the course of his reasoning simply reveals more clearly what it is. In brief, there is no verification of a religious hypothesis comparable logically to the verification of a scientific one. What purports to be verification is a labored justification of commitments already made and assumptions regarding the relations between values and facts previously adopted. There is no genuine prediction of future experiences which, if they happen in one way, establish one hypothesis as true and, if they happen in another way, establish another hypothesis as true. Unless we stretch the meaning of "empiricism" in a very confusing fashion, theology is not an empirical science.

Of course, I am aware of the fact that "experience," "empirical," and "experimental," as used in contemporary discussion, are weasel words. There is a sense in which "experience" is an all-inclusive term, covering our commerce with formal relations and with moral imperatives as well as with perceptual facts. And in its pragmatic interpretation, "experimental" characterizes a procedure that applies to decisions between values as well as to any selection among factual hypotheses. But we must not be misled by these varying connotations. My present point is simply that in none of these conceptions does an experiential method provide a way of differentiating on an impartial basis between adequate and inadequate assertions in the field of ulti-

mate values and their relations with facts.

Now secular philosophy has been slowly learning these lessons and is approaching more and more in their light its responsibility to deal reasonably with values and with problems involving their relation to facts. As it does so, a new conception of what it essentially means to be reasonable comes to light with a new method through which reason may operate. In the field of formal relations it is now clear that to be reasonable means to respect the law of contradiction. In the field of factual science it is clear that to be reasonable means to respect perceptual evidence and the inductive canons by which we tell what any given body of evidence proves. In the fields involving values, which include religion and its theological interpretation, what does it mean to be reasonable; and what sort of method is appropriate?

The answer seems to be: It means to recognize that wherever there are differences of evaluation they rest in the last analysis on differences in the criteria of values to which the diverging thinkers are severally committed; that the mere fact that one thinker inclines toward one criterion and another toward another gives neither of the two any superior plausibility; but that in the presence of these differences each is responsible to avoid arbitrariness in his decision. Now what *is* arbitrariness in this situation? It is allowing one's self to become or remain attached to a standard of value without intelligent appreciation of the standards championed by others and without systematic comparison leading to a choice of standard grounded in clear awareness of the merits and defects of each. So far as one achieves such an appreciation and engages in such a comparison he is reasonable about his value-

commitments, and the highest degree of reasonableness is realized wherever these processes are exhibited in their most impartial form. The challenging problem of contemporary philosophy is to devise a method by which this reasonableness can be adequately realized—a procedure by which the ultimate commitments of any philosophic school may be compared objectively with those of any other school, to the end that the most inclusive perspective with its appropriate commitment may be discovered and clearly delineated.

Contemporary secular thought realizes that the basic problem posed by the situation which we here confront is the problem of disagreement between champions of opposing philosophies and that no solution is reasonable if it does not provide a way by which they can advance from disagreement toward agreement. Emphasis on agreement as the crucial test of reasonableness (not agreement anyhow secured but agreement sought through mutual appreciation and shared understanding reached in the presence of all relevant factors) has now become central in discussions of problems of method. The problem, then, in dealing with criteria of values and of their relations to fact—with the contrasting commitments and opposing theories about such matters—is to find a method of passing impartially from disagreement to agreement. Wherever there is disagreement, there is error and inadequacy, in all theories but one and perhaps in all; wherever agreement is reached in this manner, a fuller truth correcting previous error has been found—a conviction proving its greater adequacy by its power to reconcile opposites in an inclusive synthesis.

There is a movement in secular philosophy today which is making this em-

phasis and gradually working out a method for applying and developing it. In American thought, phases of it are revealed in the philosophies of such men as Felix Cohen, Lodge, Sheldon, Churchman, Murphy; in oriental thought the same emphasis is finding expression in forms naturally suggested by its historical background. I believe that the most significant promise of future development in general methodology lies in this direction—that a novel major conception of reason and its way of operating will progressively emerge from this movement of thought. Later I shall attempt to state the basic principles which, in my judgment, express the essence of this new method. It is evident that its distinctive feature lies in the refusal of a thinker pursuing it to commit himself to the ultimate convictions of this or that partisan view, attempting to refute all competitors as wrong. He assumes, instead, that a more adequate perspective is to be gradually found through a process of open-minded understanding, co-operative criticism, and reasonable reconciliation participated in by the holders of varying views. True wisdom in this field is not given already by any of the theories now proposed; it is always yet to be discovered by the fuller sharing of experiences on the part of all who are eager for the best of which human life is capable and who see that every man or woman can contribute toward the clarification and realization of that supreme value.

b) Religious.—But even though theology, viewed historically, has depended for its method on the procedures successfully developed by secular thought at any given time, a proposed method that is justified merely as an application of such procedures to the field of religion might well leave us with a lurking sus-

picion. After all, religion has features which distinguish it from other subject matter. Hence even though, when previous methods have led us into a blind alley, we seem to have no recourse in our quest for a better method save to turn to the newly promising ways of thought in related fields to find what they can offer, still we will be more confident that we are on the right track if they can be seen to be harmonious with the distinctive insights of religion. And our confidence will rise to the highest possible assurance if it appears that the new way of secular thought now taking shape expresses more fully than previous theological methods have done a profound conviction on which all the great religions agree.

I think that precisely this can be shown in the case of the new procedure just briefly sketched and that theology in the past has failed in its methodology to measure up to what is implied in the highest values that religion enables men to glimpse. All the great religions agree that in some sense love is the supreme value of which human experience is capable and the most dependable clue to its adequate interpretation. The kind of love that is here envisioned is the kind whose nature is most clearly expressed in the Golden Rule, interpreted in accordance with its spirit rather than with its letter: "Put yourself sympathetically in the position of another, and act in relation to him as that appreciative understanding would suggest, knowing that you would be happy if he were to understand with similar sympathy your needs and aspirations and were always to act so far as you are concerned under the guidance of that understanding."

Now what is more radically inconsistent with the spirit of love thus conceived than intolerance or dogmatism—

than willingness to commit one's self to an ultimate value without an impartial effort to appreciate alternative values and to compare them reasonably with the one toward which inclination initially tends? This is the expression of hostility and pride, not of love, as Buddhism has consistently taught, and as persistent strains in other religions have clearly or haltingly seen. What we want another to do when we lay our convictions persuasively before him is not to allow his previous commitments and present prejudices to stand in the way of full responsiveness to the values we are ready to disclose; we want him to be sensitively open to whatever is good in them without hindrance from established habit and hoary tradition. All right, then—"Whatsoever ye would that men should do unto you, do ye even so to them." We are responsible to be appreciatively sensitive in this way to the supreme values and distinctive convictions of others, not allowing our traditional loyalties and emotionally satisfying habits to obstruct that responsiveness to what they have found good and to the vaster world that can be discovered by making it our own. What could be a more obvious expression of love in the activity of philosophical or theological interpretation than a method which guides us in sharing the world of another, in entering appreciatively into the values that he has found, and in adding to our previously limited perspective the meaning that the divine has come to have for him? What greater and more enriching adventure is there than the co-operative exploration through which such a theological method would pilot us? In what better way can we love others when engaging in the task of systematically understanding religion than by realizing, in dealing with the pre-suppositions that divide one sectarian

interpretation from another, the open and impartial state of mind of the scientist when he deals with the different hypotheses proposed for explaining a given set of facts? He avoids the temptation to commit himself in advance to one hypothesis against the others, for he is eager not to lose whatever verifiable truth there may be in any of them. So when one truly cares for other human centers of experience, he will be eager not to let his own initial predilections stand in the way of full discovery of all that their hypotheses about what is supremely worthy of devotion might contribute toward the most inclusive appreciation and understanding that man is capable of attaining.

The theologies of the great religions have given us doctrines *about* love, but as yet they have not succeeded in being an *expression* of a generous, outgoing love. Were they thoroughly consistent with their own highest ideals, they would become precisely this—they would adopt such a method as would express the quest for a democratically shared understanding of the deepest things that the experience of men can disclose. The present paper is a halting attempt to point the way in this direction.

I conclude, then, that the new methodology thus briefly sketched not only is in line with promising trends of contemporary secular thought but is also more completely harmonious than any methodology of the past with what is best in religion itself.

II. THE METHOD

Thus far what I am proposing as the "new" method has merely been described in very general terms. I now undertake the task of portraying it more fully and illustrating its use, so that its nature and significance may be better appreciated.

Such a task will include a formulation of the guiding principles which acceptance of the method assumes as sound and an outline of the main steps of procedure revealed in its employment.

a) Guiding principles.—Six principles which characterize the method when applied to any subject matter, secular or religious, will be listed first. A seventh principle, which characterizes it as applied to the specific field of religion, follows.

1. Any intellectual interpretation involving values and facts is actually (whatever its holder may believe to the contrary) relative to the limited standpoint of those who hold it—to the particular "existential" slant and the partial appreciations of goodness that they have been able to achieve. It is not universally valid, and to claim, implicitly or explicitly, that it is so is to display the sin of intellectual pride in its most serious and dangerous form.

2. There is no greater initial probability of the adequacy of any particular interpretation than there is of the adequacy of any other. Prior to responsible comparative analysis guided by the spirit of impartial generosity, all interpretations stand on exactly the same footing. The mere fact that I happen to incline toward a given interpretation and find its categories peculiarly helpful in mapping out the universe as I experience it proves nothing about the objective probability of that interpretation. Other thinkers, with equal right, will incline toward other viewpoints, and their choices are initially just as plausible as mine.

3. But, despite the limitations of this relativity, any thinker is able in some measure to respond to the interpretations proposed by others and to gain a more inclusive perspective in which they

can be compared with his own previous interpretation. The way of progress lies in this direction, and the pursuit of such a perspective is the work of reason in this field.

4. What kind of criterion may properly be employed in the comparative assessment of divergent interpretations cannot be determined by anyone in advance. It can only be determined through co-operative discovery of what each interpretation is able to accomplish, not only in providing clarified understanding of the universe, but also in guiding other insistent human needs (practical and emotional) toward their richest possible fulfillment. To commit one's self to any criterion in advance of this process of shared discovery is to blind one's self to the fruitful possibilities that other proposed criteria might exhibit.

5. Different interpretations should hence be regarded as different hypotheses in quest of completion, not as claimants to the status of established truth. Their distinctive character as philosophical rather than as scientific hypotheses lies in the fact that, instead of covering this or that restricted area of human experience only, they are inclusive hypotheses, seeking meaningful application to everything whatever to which man's thought can be directed.

6. The appropriate presumption to guide the systematic study and detailed assessment is that each, especially the historically influential ones, has a significant positive contribution to make, without which our understanding of the universe would be poorer than it now can be and our power of adjustment to its demands less effective. It should be assumed, also, that the contribution can in all cases be given articulate expression, although lengthy and patient analysis may be required to accomplish this in impartial form.

When these six principles are applied specifically to the field of theology, they result in the following assumption:

7. The God that is ultimately real, and therefore the true object of man's religious reverence, is none of the gods already given in any limited or sectarian tradition but the God embodying all the greatness that the vision of sincere men and women throughout the whole world and in all generations can progressively discover, as those visions are lovingly shared. The God yet to be found in this way is more real than any god already found or that anybody might wish to protect from this co-operative process. The same principle applies to the ultimate meaning of other basic religious concepts, such as "soul," "faith," "church," and "salvation."

b) Steps of procedure.—It remains to sketch the main steps of procedure which the method determined by the adoption of these principles would follow and to illustrate them. It will be obvious that this procedure can operate only so far as there is readiness on the part of participants to take their values tentatively rather than absolutely, in the interest of coming to appreciate impartially whatever is good in the values of others. It provides a concrete way of rendering that readiness effective. And even if only one participant as yet feels this readiness, his exemplification of the basic attitude involved will elicit a similar attitude on the part of others as rapidly as is possible. He is saying to them in effect: "You doubtless have something good—in your criterion of truth, of value, and of reality—that I have thus far missed. I would like to share it with you and to share also whatever proves to be good in my own previous notions on these things."

These steps may best be introduced by observing what is implied by these prin-

ciples about our criterion of theological understanding. In the past, theologians (and the same, of course, has been true of philosophers working in other fields than religion) have felt themselves in the dilemma of either having no criterion at all or applying a criterion which reflects the partisan assumptions that they have already adopted. But it now appears that there is a third alternative: even though no impartial criterion is at present given, such a criterion may gradually emerge through the process of seeking to pass from initial disagreement to agreement. It may do so because such passage is always possible in some measure whenever opposing thinkers sincerely attempt it.

1. The first step of co-operative procedure follows at once from this consideration. The initial analysis that is needed in dealing with any serious intellectual problem is its analysis into those matters on which agreement can already be assumed and which, therefore, are objective and publicly sharable and those matters on which agreement has not yet been attained, in which, for that reason, no objective character is yet found. The concepts by which we refer to the former can be given fairly definite and unambiguous connotation, while the concepts by which we refer to the latter are inevitably vague and ambiguous; their meaning remains to be determined through the process of achieving fuller agreement. This analysis is foundational to all else because progress toward a larger measure of agreement can start only from accurate recognition of the relevant points on which agreement already exists and those on which it is still lacking. Whenever our assumptions on this matter prove mistaken, they have to be corrected before we can proceed further. Also, the matters on which opposing thinkers now agree provide the preliminary medium for communication

between them; if they disagreed on everything they could not even talk intelligibly to each other, and no progress toward fuller agreement could begin. At least a shared understanding of the meanings of certain words is essential to the co-operative exploration of whatever is not yet shared.

2. The next step follows from the circumstance that in the area of disagreement the aim is to make progress toward free and friendly agreement. The categories which are appropriate to employ at this juncture are those of "ends" and "means"; this step can be stated best in such terms. The reason is a simple one. Opposing thinkers have previously adopted their partisan assumptions on these disputed matters dogmatically, as ultimate commitments. Now, since they are participating in a co-operative process of mutual criticism, aiming at a more inclusive position, these assumptions are reduced to a less than ultimate status; the ultimate is something yet to be discovered through that process. A natural way of describing this situation is to say that that ultimate yet to be discovered constitutes the common end sought by all participants in the controversy, while their varying sets of partisan assumptions constitute different means which they are severally proposing for the realization of that end. If, for example, Protestants and Catholics were to subject their differences to co-operative adjustment in this manner, each party would regard its own present conception of the relation between the ecclesiastical community and the individual not as a dogmatic commitment but as an alternative way of realizing an end which transcends what both previous doctrines have envisioned.

3. The third step involves the solution of a linguistic problem. We need an impartial terminology in which to denote

this common ultimate end and by whose aid, later, we shall compare objectively the alternative means proposed for its realization. At present such a terminology is lacking. Each school uses its own preferred categories in which to state not only its own position but also the positions of its various rivals. But this is inevitably prejudicial in favor of its own doctrine and against all competing doctrines. The very meaning of the words that it uses is affected by its distinctive commitments; they imply the soundness of its own conclusions and the falsity of the conclusions of others. When the Catholic, for example, uses the word "sacrament," he means by it not only the acts that are performed but also a particular interpretation of those acts which reflects the Catholic conception of the church and its role in mediating salvation to its members; when the Protestant uses the same word, he means an interpretation which reflects the quite different Protestant conception of the way in which the individual participates in God's saving grace. Obviously, discussion by opposing thinkers through the use of such terms is futile. Only when, in addition to adopting a common end, they have accepted an impartial word or phrase by which to refer to it and are thus able to describe their opposing positions in objective relation to that common end can the discussion be continued with some hope of reaching a larger measure of agreement.

This vital step may be illustrated by what has happened during the last half-century in the field of ethical theory. In the nineteenth century the two main competing ethical theories were the utilitarian and the Kantian. Each had its chosen terminology in which it stated all ethical issues; the utilitarian analyzed them in terms of "good" or "bad"

choices of means to "general happiness," while the Kantian analyzed them in terms of "right" or "wrong," their rightness or wrongness being determined by measuring them against an absolute and universal rule. Neither of these positions could be fairly stated in terms of the language preferred by the other, for the two sets of categories involved incompatible assumptions. Today this situation is partially remedied by the increasing employment in ethical theory of the still more general concept of "value," which had already gained a quasi-impartiality through its use in the science of economics. When the utilitarian and the Kantian state their contrasting positions in terms of this more ultimate category, the theories become comparable in an objective way; the issue now becomes a matter of choosing between the values realized by selecting appropriate means for wise social ends and the values realized by applying a universal rule of conduct to all our acts. Instead of being limited to viewing both theories through the partisan eyes of one or the other, and thus failing to achieve unbiased understanding, we can view them from a common external focus which is nonpartisan.

Viewed from the standpoint of the need satisfied in this third step, the fourth and the fifth steps consist in a further development of this nonpartisan language. By engaging in the comparative analysis and synthesis now required, the language is extended to cover relevant details as well as the general principles in their major opposition to each other.

4. The fourth step is the systematic analysis of each of the contrasting positions in terms of this impartial language, to bring out as objectively as possible the distinctive virtues and defects of each. This analysis, in other words, will at-

tempt to reveal the precise contribution which each position can make toward the common end in the light of which they are being compared and in what respects the contribution of one is more valuable than that of the others and in what respects it is less so. Of course, the analysis is not a merely formal matter, in the sense that anybody who knows how to reason consistently would be able to perform it. In this field the meanings of the terms employed can only be caught by one who penetrates sympathetically into the heart of the religious position being analyzed, so as to appreciate its value to those who hold it.

5. The final step is the progressive synthesis of the superior values which emerge from this analysis into a perspective richer and more inclusive than any of the positions with which the process began—a perspective which preserves all that is of dependable virtue in each of these positions, so far as it can be preserved, and integrates them into a harmonious whole. Mature thinking does not stop short with objective, critical analysis. It inevitably goes on to synthesis, because its controlling interest is to discover and share the value-insights of other thinkers, and they cannot be shared without being brought together in peaceful unity with the values already glimpsed.

This five-step process needs to be carried out on three levels of increasing generality. And it can be carried out on all of them at the same time.

Assuming a starting-point within the Christian field, which most Westerners would naturally do, the first level consists in its application to the competing sectarian interpretations of Christianity in the interest of developing a genuinely ecumenical theology. The second consists in working out by its aid a reconcil-

ing synthesis between the different religions of the world to the end that nothing dependably good in any of these various approaches to the divine need be missed in the further growth of each. The process of discovering one's larger self is more rapid and more deeply satisfying according as the difference between what he has been and what he is now seeking to become is greater; the expansion realized is more revolutionary and more thrilling. The third consists in the continual appropriation by religion of the values newly emerging in the secular experience of men, so that their spiritual significance is fully realized. Some of the greatest insights of theology in the past have been gained by turning to the values found in happy family life—in the relation of father to child, brother to brother, husband to wife. It is important that this process continue, for there is always the possibility of further advance if religion remains responsive to newly discovered goods in all areas of human experience, such as art, literature, friendship, science, and responsible statesmanship, as well as the family. The most threatening religious conflict today is not between different Christian sects and not even between Christianity and other religions now recognized as such; it is between communism and what all these religions have traditionally emphasized. This is a religious conflict, because communism expresses a religious devotion to certain economic and social values to whose spiritual possibilities traditional religions have as yet been insufficiently responsive.

For an illustration of the way in which I conceive that these steps would work out in dealing with a concrete problem, let us consider a case which belongs to the second level just described. This is the problem of synthesizing the distinc-

tive values of Christianity with those of Mahayana Buddhism.

At the first step it would be discovered, among other things, that a fundamental focus of agreement between these two religions lies in the belief of each that an outgoing love for others is the culminating mark of true spiritual achievement. Common acceptance of this value provides, then, an initial core of mutual understanding on which a larger measure of understanding and of agreement could be built. Among the fundamental points of disagreement would be those resulting from the fact that in Jewish-Christian history this ideal has been clarified by successive revisions in the Hebrew concept of a personal God and the Christian doctrine of redemption through the death of Christ, while in Buddhist history it has been clarified by successive transformations in the concept of the spiritual state gradually reached by disciplined conquest of human craving and in the bodhisattva "gift of returning." These disagreements pose very serious difficulties.

At the second step irenic-minded Christians and Buddhists would accept the principle that the disagreements, however serious, are not to be regarded as final. Where their conceptions and doctrines conflict, they are to be viewed not as objects of unconditional loyalty but as proposed means for the realization of a common end, which does not now exist but which is to emerge from the cooperative and mutually appreciative comparison of these alternative means. This end will largely consist of the completer fellow-feeling into which the love on which they already agree will develop as a result of this process.

The third step will involve the definition of this end in a nonpartisan language. Since impartiality here is essen-

tial, we could not pick for this purpose the term "love," for this to us would carry a distinctively Christian meaning, nor the term "compassion," for this would carry a distinctively Buddhist meaning. Some neutral term will have to be discovered which, whether rendered in a Western or in an Eastern language, would involve no prejudice either in favor of the one religious conception or in favor of the other. Such a term might be: "the glad giving of self, for the sake of the good of others." It is important to remember that, although this term must be neutral, it must also be so chosen as to preserve as fully as possible the vital warmth of the partisan concepts it replaces and to absorb that warmth into itself; no pale, dry term of compromise will do. Then, other Christian and Buddhist doctrines will be described objectively in their relation to the nonpartisan ideal thus denoted. For example, the Christian doctrine of forgiveness would become "the way to self-giving through the participation of one's old self in the death of Christ and the release of a new self into oneness with a self-giving God"; while the corresponding Buddhist doctrine would become "the way to self-giving through awareness and rejection of the self-seeking cravings which now dominate us and the realization of oneness with all other craving and suffering sentient beings which comes as a result of such self-mastery."

As the fourth step the participants in this process would systematically analyze, in the light of these impartial formulations, the history and present experience of the two religions in order to compare their virtues and defects as objectively as possible. In what respects and under what conditions does the Christian way secure the full release in

happy oneness with others of all the energy, all the emotion, all the intellectual power of men and women? In what respects and under what conditions does the Buddhist way secure this? Only searching analysis of this sort can reach an answer to such crucial questions.

Finally, as the fifth step, the task will be that of progressively integrating what proves dependably valuable in each religion into an inclusive, harmonious whole, which would constitute a richer and completer way of meeting man's spiritual needs than either religion could ever provide by itself. This integration, of course, cannot be accomplished in any arbitrary, not to say mechanical, fashion; it can only come as the result of an actual growing together of the two faiths as adherents of each become eager not to miss the more abundant life that can be found by appreciating and making their own the contribution offered by the other. The method here outlined gives that eagerness a procedure for expressing itself effectively—for realizing its aim with a minimum of waste and lost motion.

This method is, I conceive, self-corrective, in the same fundamental sense in which the procedure of inductive science is self-corrective. Whenever a scientist finds himself unable to draw confident generalizations from the evidence now at hand, all that he needs is to enlarge his sample in accordance with the same canons employed in securing the sample that has proved inadequate. If appropriate data are available, sooner or later he will possess a sample large enough to permit warranted generalizations; it will be

a fair sample of the whole field of data to which the generalizations are supposed to apply. The case is similar with the method in theology here sketched. If in pursuing it the theologian finds himself blocked at any time in his progress toward a richer and more inclusive system of theological understanding, all that is necessary is to perform the procedures involved in a yet more patient, careful, and thorough manner. If the barrier is capable of being removed, it can be removed in this way. He will find that there is needed, perhaps, a still more impartial language in which to state the issues between the opposing schools, or more detailed and accurate analysis of the conflicting doctrines in terms of this language, or more systematic comparison to bring out objective virtues and weaknesses of each, or throughout the entire process a more sincere readiness to allow diverging original convictions to become revised to whatever extent is needed. By such corrections whatever further progress is possible toward the goal of fuller sharing and a wider area of friendly agreement will be achieved. At the same time I do not mean to claim that the method as here described is perfect. It is proposed as a means to the end of loving unity in religion and democratic co-operation in theology; as such, it is subject to progressive correction, just as the method of science is. The reader is hereby invited to participate in the co-operative improvement of this method, so that as the years pass it will fill its role more and more efficiently.